

Reverse Engineering as a Component of Digital Ethnography: Studying Platformic Management on Honor

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Abstract

Ethnographic studies of online labor platforms rarely involve analysis of proprietary platform code. This poster proposes reverse engineering of mobile apps as a way to circumvent access barriers and provide digital ethnographers additional material to study. We applied this reverse engineering method to the home care platform Honor to study how the platform organizes labor and disciplines workers. Simultaneously, we conducted a discourse analysis of digital documents (webpages, blog posts, and videos) published by Honor. The combination of these methods produced greater insights than either method on its own. We found that workers' autonomy to set preferences and control their schedules is limited by both algorithmic opacity and social norms, and that gamification of labor is framed as "career growth." The findings in this poster demonstrate how studying reverse-engineered code alongside other, traditional sources of ethnographic data can strengthen claims about platformic management when studying online labor platforms.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Collaborative and social computing design and evaluation methods**; Smartphones; • **Security and privacy** → **Software reverse engineering**.

Keywords

reverse engineering, home care, algorithmic management, platformic management, care work, labor platforms, digital ethnography

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1 Introduction

Online labor platforms are an increasingly common way of organizing work. To workers, they offer the flexibility and autonomy to

choose when and how much they work, with lower commitment than in a traditional employment relationship. Platform workers are not employees within a traditional management structure, but (typically) freelancers managed by algorithms, monetary incentives, and (often asymmetric) customer rating systems [4, 15, 17, 20, 23, 24, 31]. Scholars have coined the term *algorithmic management* to describe the use of algorithms to assign work and discipline workers [19, 20], and *platformic management* to describe how algorithms work together with interface design, policies, and norms to regulate the performance of work on labor platforms [17].

Platformic management often undercuts the autonomy that draws workers to platforms in the first place [5–7, 27, 32]. In care work specifically, platforms undermine workers' temporal autonomy by encouraging clients to expect on-demand connection (online therapy [16]); creating unbalanced power dynamics such that workers will absorb the cost of delays or comply with last-minute requests to avoid bad reviews from clients (beauty work [4, 22]); and requiring workers to perform availability in order to stay visible in search results (child care [9, 30]).

If ethnographers want to open the "black box" of a platform to understand its mechanisms and how they shape workers' experiences, what are our options? One option is to gain ethnographic "access" by approaching gatekeepers (e.g., company leadership) and getting permission to study the platform. A researcher who does this potentially gains access to many kinds of data; they can perhaps talk to employees, sit in on meetings, see internal strategy and design documents, and view platform code. But this kind of access is hard to achieve, is not absolute, and may be limiting in certain ways [26].

Alternatively, researchers can do what Seaver [26] has called "scavenging": piecing together data from various sources, while paying attention to what is easily accessible and what is hidden. We can read documents that the company has published [23]; read workers' online forum discussions about the platform [20, 24]; interview workers and clients [20, 23, 24]; and, in some cases, potentially become a worker or client [23]. This last option is not viable for all platforms, however. Becoming a platform worker is relatively easy in the case of ride-sharing and food delivery platforms; it is prohibitively difficult for care work that requires specialized skills, training, and long-term relationships with clients.

Another option for the scavenging ethnographer is to analyze the platform's code for clues into its internal structure. While non-insiders cannot get direct access to proprietary platform code, we can reconstruct some of it through reverse engineering [10, 29]. Most labor platforms have a mobile app that allows workers to



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interface with the platform. Android apps can be (relatively easily) decompiled into Java and/or Kotlin code. There are many limitations to this method: some code won't decompile correctly; the decompiled code will not include comments; and you will not have access to backend, server-side code. Nevertheless, it is a useful source of data, especially when combined with other methods and data sources in a digital ethnography.

As a proof of concept, this poster describes how we reverse-engineered a home care platform app, the Honor Care Pro app [2], in conjunction with a discourse analysis of documents (webpages, blog posts, and videos) published by Honor. The two methods worked synergistically: the analysis of documents helped us know what to look for in the code (a challenge because we did not have direct access to the UI), and the code provided valuable context for interpreting the documents. Our work contributes to HCI by demonstrating that reverse engineering can be a useful component of platform studies and perhaps digital ethnographies in general.

2 Background on Honor

Honor is one of many technology startups responding to the “crisis” caused by the aging U.S. population: the number of older adults needing care is growing, and the number of care workers is not keeping pace [25]. Although Honor’s promotional materials credit its innovative technology, Honor’s real innovation is the way it organizes labor. Unlike a typical on-demand labor platform [31] (whose workers are considered to be independent contractors) or marketplace platform [31] (where individual clients hire individual workers directly), Honor directly employs and manages home care workers who visit clients’ homes to provide personal care, house-keeping, and companionship. It resembles a scaled-up version of a home care agency, with a workforce distributed across 14 states and managed through a digital platform [13]. Honor acquired the Home Instead network of home care agencies in 2021 and has adopted Home Instead as its client-facing brand identity. The Home Instead franchises and independent “partner” agencies handle client relationships while “business tasks like scheduling, billing and payroll” are centrally managed by Honor [11]. For reverse engineering, we targeted the Honor Care Pro app [2], the mobile app that home care workers employed by Honor use to manage their schedules, view information about their clients, clock in and out, record completed tasks, and communicate with clients’ other caregivers. Clients and their family members interact with the platform through a separate app, Honor Family [14].

3 Methods

3.1 Discourse analysis

The discourse analysis of Honor’s public documents is part of a larger study that compares three home care platforms with different structures in order to understand how each platform mediates the relationships between home care workers and clients, and by extension, workers’ temporal autonomy. The documents that platforms publish—which include advertisements, how-to’s, advice, employee recognitions, job postings, and more—provide insights into the explicit and implicit messages that platform companies are sending to workers and clients about how they should behave and what they can expect from the platform. The second author collected

online documents from each platform and conducted a discourse analysis [8, 21] to answer the following research questions:

- (1) What vision of temporal autonomy does each platform present to workers? What promises are they making to workers about the kind of temporal autonomy they will have on the platform?
- (2) What expectations does the platform set, and what norms of behavior it is trying to establish, with respect to worker-client relationships?

The documents pertaining to Honor were collected between March 31, 2025 and May 29, 2025, with publication dates ranging from March 2016 to May 2025. They were sourced from Honor’s website, YouTube channel, and Vimeo channel, as well as the website and YouTube channel of Home Instead, Honor’s client-facing subsidiary.¹ We preserved every page (that we could access) of each company’s website, excluding blog posts, news coverage, educational resources, and job postings. Blog posts, educational resources, job postings, and videos were collected based on relevance: if they pertained to matching and scheduling, expectations about time, or worker-client relationships, we included them in our data set. The final data set for Honor included 58 videos (196.9 total minutes), 35 blog posts, and 19 web pages.

After briefly reading or viewing all documents, the second author sorted them by their relevance to our research questions. Each document was labeled as “High,” “Medium high,” “Medium,” “Low medium,” or “Low” relevance. Documents that were primarily about matching and scheduling received a “High” rating; documents that set general expectations for worker-client relationships but did not mention time were rated “Medium”; and those that only obliquely featured worker-client relationships were rated “Low”. All documents of at least “Medium high” relevance were subjected to more careful reading, memoing, and open coding for discursive claims and explicit or implicit normative statements. (For example, the codes included “a large worker base requires computational matching,” “clients should have frequent shifts with their preferred worker,” and “good workers are frequently requested by clients”). The second author also read and coded 8 out of 17 care worker appreciation blog posts, containing a total of 123 single-paragraph appreciations, to identify the most commonly mentioned care worker virtues.² The findings we report here were arrived at through integrative memoing and discussion with a collaborator.

3.2 Reverse engineering the Honor app

The reverse engineering project began in summer of 2024. We initially targeted three candidate applications within the home care ecosystem for algorithmic analysis. Following the methodology established by Stevens [29], we attempted to unpack these apps by downloading the APKs from the Google Play store and running them through a Java decompiler (javadecompiler.com) to get a readable, reverse-engineered version of the code. Two of the three apps included advanced obfuscation and anti-decompilation measures that rendered the logic flow difficult or impossible to read. We chose

¹Honor acquired Home Instead in 2021. Home Instead videos and blog posts from before the acquisition were not included in the document analysis.

²Many of the appreciations were formulaic and used the same or similar terms, so 8 blog posts was enough to reach saturation.

to focus on the third app, Honor Care Pro, because it was the most accessible.

3.2.1 Proxy interface analysis through documents. Once the code was decompiled, the challenge was to find relevant code to analyze within a large file structure that included significant amounts of vendor and open source code unrelated to the management of care workers. Our initial guidebook, Stevens' dissertation [29], relied on the ability to access the app and match up the code to functionality (e.g., noting the presence of a button in the user interface and then locating the corresponding code for storing or retrieving data). In our case, we could not directly access the Honor Care Pro app because its use is restricted to Honor employees. Anyone can download the app, but only care workers with valid credentials can access its functionality. We needed a way to home in on relevant code without being able to see and interact with the user interface.

This is one way in which the document analysis proved useful. Reading the documents gave us a greater familiarity with the terms Honor uses; moreover, some of the videos we collected included screenshots or demos of flows in the Care Pro app. From these documents, we were able to identify terms related to labor tracking and scheduling that corresponded to Java classes, such as "CareNote" and "Achievement." These keywords were also used to query the strings.xml file and AndroidManifest file for relevant text and metadata.

3.2.2 Following the data. SQL queries within the decompiled source served as anchors, drawing our attention to points where the app interacted with its local database. We used the "Find Usages" feature of IntelliJ to work backwards (tracing a data point to its origin/input) and forwards (tracing how that data was transformed or displayed). This allowed us to bridge the gap between raw database schemas and the UI elements described in marketing materials.

3.2.3 Mapping class structure and relationships. Since decompilation strips developer comments, we reconstructed the app's internal logic by manually exploring and annotating parts of the code. We isolated specific classes (e.g., JobOffer) and documented their attributes and methods in a Google Doc. We tagged these attributes with questions and observational notes. As we explored attributes and related classes, we created a conceptual map of the software. For instance: JobOffer has a CareProviderJob object as one of its attributes, which in turn has a User object as an attribute. By analyzing each of these custom classes and the relationships between them, we began to piece together the developers' intended logic for caregiver monitoring and task prioritization.

3.2.4 Architectural Inference (MVVM and Logic Boundaries). A primary challenge was distinguishing between client-side processing (which we theoretically had access to) and black-box server-side logic (which we did not). By analyzing file structures, we identified two critical architectural components:

- **Model-View-ViewModel (MVVM):** The presence of View-Model files indicated a clear separation between UI updates (View) and data logic (Model). This helped us isolate where the app translates data for the user. We were able to find these because the file names ended in "ViewModel."

- **Apache Thrift:** We identified the use of Thrift for defining service interfaces. This revealed the boundary of our visibility; while we could determine what data was sent and received (the inputs and outputs), the specific transition logic occurring on the server remained unreachable.

Understanding the software design patterns and APIs was important because it helped us parse what logic was accessible to us (What is being processed client side?) and what logic was not (What is being processed server side?). This helped us determine the scope of our investigation into the apps.

4 Findings

In this section, we briefly summarize some of our findings about algorithmic management at Honor. We plan to provide more in-depth answers to our research questions in a future paper. For this poster, our goal is to illustrate how reverse engineering and discourse analysis can be productively combined in a digital ethnography.

4.1 Algorithmic management at Honor

4.1.1 Treatment of worker preferences. Promotional videos and blog posts stress that Honor supports workers by giving them "the tools and resources they need to do their job well" [18] and treating their needs and preferences as valid. This treatment is contrasted with an imagined alternative that is impersonal, where workers are treated as interchangeable, arbitrarily assigned to shifts without regard for their preferences, overworked, underpaid, and unappreciated. Honor promises "care pros" that they will have agency in creating their schedules and choosing their clients. The design of the Care Pro app creates a feeling of agency by providing workers with "offers" and "recommendations" of both one-off and recurring shifts that they can choose to accept or decline. These offers of work are selected for workers based on the preferences and schedule availability that they record in the app (among other factors). According to Honor's CEO, the company's matching algorithm also takes into account "revealed preferences" inferred from workers' actions in the app (e.g., patterns in the types of shift they accept or decline) [28]. Consistent with this claim, a message in the Suggested Job Offers flow ("done_responding_to_suggested_offers_message") urges workers to respond to every offer because "Responding to all recommended shifts helps us learn which shifts you like best."

The decompiled code clarifies what schedule preferences workers are able to set through the app and, to some extent, how those preferences are used. An UpdateWorkPreferencesRequest object contains a list of time slots (each consisting of a day of the week, start time, and duration), a target number of weekly hours, and a list of "work types" that can include "WEEKLY," "ONE_OFF," or both. It seems that the selected time slots are not binding for either the worker or the platform, however. The strings.xml file contains the message, "Thanks for setting your work preferences. We'll keep them in mind when reaching out about clients, and you can always apply for shifts outside of these times. [...] We may still contact you for shifts outside these preferences."

These findings show that workers' agency in setting schedule preferences is not absolute. They do not have the ability to set hard limits, temporal or otherwise, on the offers they are shown. Their

expressed preferences are only a part of the optimization problem that Honor’s matching algorithm is trying to solve.

4.1.2 Pressure to accept shift offers. It is unclear how much freedom workers actually have to decline shift offers. The job application for an Honor Care Professional in Allentown, Pennsylvania stipulates several schedule requirements, including the requirement to “accept visits within your availability and staffing preferences” [3]. This suggests that workers will face consequences if they decline shifts that match their expressed preferences. What exactly those consequences are, how they are administered, and under what precise conditions, we were not able to determine. We do know from the code that when a worker declines a recurring/weekly shift offer, a decline reason is logged and sent to the backend, potentially to be viewed by a human manager at Honor.

Additionally, Honor’s employee appreciation blog posts (published monthly from September 2021 through January 2023) give the impression of a work culture that strongly encourages care workers to take on extra work for the good of their clients and the company. The appreciations contain many mentions of this or that worker being a “team player” and “looking for ways to help out” or being “always willing to help out.” Workers are praised for taking on extra shifts and accepting undesirable shifts. For example, one manager gushes, “Doretta is the epitome of an amazing Care Pro! [...] She works short shifts, extra-long shifts, shifts near and far. You name it, she’ll work it.” [1] Small choices in the UI design seem to reinforce this norm and create subtle pressure on workers to accept extra shifts. A screenshot of the Care Pro app in one video [12] shows a notification telling the user that new shifts have opened up with one of their repeat clients: “Arlette Johnson has new shifts available. Want to help?” The phrase “Want to help?” invokes the norm of good workers being “willing to help out.” It implies a judgment on the worker who says no, because a virtuous worker who cares about their clients and is a “team player” will of course “want to help.”

4.1.3 Achievement tiers and pay premiums. What supposedly sets Honor apart from other platforms and home care agencies is the way they treat home care workers as skilled professionals [18]. Based on the documents we analyzed, being “treated like a professional” means working a consistent number of hours each week; having respect, recognition, and support from one’s employer; being monetarily valued and invested in; and having opportunities for career growth. Career growth, however, seems to be narrowly defined as advancing in the tier system that Honor uses to rank workers. A blog post by the CTO asserts that in the Honor system, “Standardized and consistent feedback delivered frequently and fairly creates learning loops that can help professionals grow in their careers,” and “Great Care Pros get rewarded” [18]. In the Honor app, feedback comes in the form of customer ratings (from clients or their family members) and scores based on a variety of metrics. The reward is advancing to higher tiers and receiving corresponding wage premiums.

From the code, we can see that the system tracks at least 15 metrics that get aggregated into scores for “timeliness” (how often a worker has been on time, late, or “very late”), “client consistency” (presumably, how often a worker takes shifts with the same clients), “app usage” (how consistently a worker uses the app to confirm

shifts, clock in and out, record tasks, and write care notes), and “call offs” (how often a worker has “called off” and needed to be replaced for a scheduled shift, and how much notice they gave the company). In each of these four categories, plus “average weekly hours” and “months worked,” the worker is assigned a tier (0-3). Tiers 2 and 3 come with wage premiums, which the app retrieves from the server via a `GetCurrentAchievementTierPremiumsResponse` object.

There may be other ways that Honor Care Pros receive feedback. Some aspects of Honor’s platformic management—for instance, the role of human managers—remain opaque given the data we have access to. However, it seems clear that these quantitative measures of timeliness, app usage, and so on play a large role in how workers are evaluated and incentivized on the Honor platform. This particular type of feedback is not likely to create “learning loops” and help workers “grow in their careers” [18]; rather, it tells workers how well they are conforming to Honor’s expectations for “professional” behavior. It is an algorithmic mechanism for disciplining workers, not for helping them develop their skills or explore potential career paths.

5 Limitations

As mentioned earlier, we only moved forward with one of three candidate apps because it was the only one to decompile into easily readable java code. This choice was motivated in part by time constraints: we chose to spend our limited time analyzing the Honor Care Pro app in depth rather than figuring out how to extract usable code from the other apps. It is worth noting that neither of the authors had prior experience with Android development. A skilled Android developer might be able to understand the apps’ structure more intuitively and find workarounds for some of the problems that stumped us, potentially opening up more code to analysis. However, the fact that we lacked that expertise and still derived valuable information from reverse engineering testifies to the usefulness of this method.

For the app we were able to deobfuscate, we only had access to client side code. Although we were able to discover a lot of information about how the developers encoded attributes of a home care client, caregiver, and labor, the algorithms that assigned values to some of those attributes were encoded on the server, which we had no access to. Our investigation was limited to seeing what information was being passed into those deciding functions and what was being returned. This naturally limits the conclusions we can draw about backend processes. Reverse engineering a mobile app is not equivalent to working directly with a platform company and having access to their code base. Rather, it is a useful tactic for researchers who cannot get such access or who choose to remain independent of the companies they are studying.

6 Conclusion: Reverse engineering as a component of digital ethnography

Reverse engineering, on its own, could only give us a very partial understanding of Honor’s platformic management mechanisms. But as part of a scavenging ethnography [26], it can be extremely useful. In our case, the combination of reverse engineering and discourse analysis of documents yielded more insight than either of these methods in isolation.

On a basic level, the documents provided useful context that helped us to navigate and interpret the code. Meanwhile, the decompiled code gave us valuable information that was not included in the public-facing documents, such as the exact text of messages shown to workers when setting schedule preferences, and the list of metrics that the app collects to assess workers' performance. Digging into the code was one way to critically evaluate the claims made by Honor's leadership in promotional blog posts and ads.

On a deeper level, our analysis of the Honor app code was an extension of the discourse analysis. Code is evidence, not only of how a software system functions, but also of how the developers thought about the activities and relationships the system is designed to support [10]. The structures of classes tell us what abstractions the designers used to facilitate care work and what aspects of these concepts they deem important. The possible values of enums like TimeOfDay ("morning," "afternoon," "evening," and "overnight") and Gender ("male," "female," and "other") illustrate both the scope of possibilities within the system (e.g., a user cannot be identified with a specific gender that is not "male" or "female") and the scope of the designers' thinking. Combined with Honor's published documents, the code we were able to reconstruct enables a richer understanding of how the platform disciplines care work.

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